SANDEEP BABURAO DABHADE, 35
Aurangabad

PACKING A PUNCH

Five years on, Phoenix Industries has survived many obstacles, including COVID, and now runs two units offering packaging solutions

By ISRAR CHISHTY



FACT SHEET

Name of company
Phoenix Industries

What they do
Packaging for an array of sectors

Founded in: 2019

Annual turnover
Rs 5.3 crore

Born in a farming family in Jalna district, Maharashtra, Sandeep Dabhade grew up with limited means. His father barely earned Rs 1-1.5 lakh a year. Despite the family's financial struggles, Dabhade's life was steeped in music. His father, Baburao Dabhade, was a respected *kirtankar* and skilled tabla player, and sparked the love for rhythm and melody in his son too. After finishing his 12th grade in Badnapur tehsil, Sandeep moved to Pune to pursue a BA in Economics, while also enrolling in a diploma course in music. He went on to complete an MA in music.

That latter strand played a big part in Dabhade's life those days: the side gigs financed his studies. He remembers performing at various venues across Maharashtra, especially an electrifying evening at a cultural event in Pune, sitting cross-legged on stage, coaxing intricate rhythms from his tabla as the audience swayed to his beats. Travelling from town to town, he would earn Rs 2,000-3,000 per show, but life was hard. "There were days when even two meals were a luxury. Sometimes I had to survive on *pav* and chutney," he recalls.

Dabhade has come a long way since then. The turn came in 2013 when he began working at a packaging company in Waluj MIDC (Maharashtra Industrial Development Corporation) industrial zone in Aurangabad (now Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar), where he was soon handling operations, marketing, accounts and logistics. In January 2019, armed with his savings and a small sum raised by mortgaging the family gold, Sandeep launched Eco Pack Industries in a 3,500 sq. ft rented space. He began trading